inflicted by the international game. It features different characters with contrasting strengths and weaknesses, united by the responsibility of providing firm foundations.

Disregarding dalliances with the likes of Vaughan, KP, Trotty, Moeen Ali and Joe Root, it is largely a story of seeking Strauss Mark 2. Jarrod Kimber of ESPNcricinfo, who has rightly underlined the unfairness of the process, worked out that I had scored around 60 per cent of the runs in England's opening stands since our six-year partnership came to an end.

It's more nuanced than that. Over the past three or four years we took a strategic decision to play on home wickets that did a bit. There's no disrespect intended in that policy; Jimmy and Stuart Broad, principal beneficiaries, are extraordinary bowlers, whose ability to exploit traditional English conditions has enabled us to win Test matches.

The flipside is that with a brand new Dukes ball and a bit of grass on the wicket it became hard work for us to build an innings. The first twenty or thirty overs were tricky, especially given the level of scrutiny my less experienced partners were enduring. There were times I sensed their tension: they didn't have the leeway my longevity afforded me.

None of us are perfect, technically. Few sportsmen are so exposed to trial by slow motion and multiple-angled replay. Getting through the first cycle of Test appearances is fiendishly difficult, because there is no hiding place. Occasionally, as in the case of Michael Carberry in that train-wreck tour of Australia in 2014, a player is simply in the wrong place at the wrong time.

Once a flaw is identified it is worked on, coldly and with disconcerting effect. Alex Hales, employed for aggressive intent, became frustrated and couldn't duplicate his short-form impact. Ben Duckett struggled on tough turning wickets. Sam Robson and Keaton Jennings each scored hundreds without curing their problems outside off stump.

Adam Lyth looked terrific in scoring 107 against New Zealand in his second Test, on his home ground of Headingley, but struggled against Australia's fast bowlers in the subsequent Ashes series victory. My opening partnership with Mark Stoneman, which encompassed eleven matches, has the lowest average, 18.8 runs, in England's Test history.

But, again, statistics scratch the surface of the story. There is an enduring bond between opening partners, however brief or relatively unproductive the relationships. Shared experience helps to develop a unique form of friendships; Alice and I remain close to Mark and his wife Serene.